Cuban territory. This overture hit Castro in his most painful spot: Khrushchev's proposal questioned not only Castro's control over the Soviet missiles but also over Cuban territory. But the Cuban leader had his answer ready. "It is our understanding," said Castro, "that … they were referring to some kind of inspection outside Cuba's national territory—inasmuch as the premier of the Soviet Union could not talk about verification on Cuban territory, since that is something that concerns only the revolutionary government of Cuba."

Castro was prepared to repeat the same statement publicly in a speech that he was to deliver the same evening. U Thant asked him not to do so: "[T]his could create some division or some misunderstanding between the Soviet Union and Cuba." Ironically, it was U Thant and not Castro who was worried about possible misunderstandings between Moscow and Havana.[21]

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CASTRO COULD PREVENT UN PERSONNEL FROM INSPECTING the missile sites, and indeed barred U Thant from visiting them, but he could not prevent the secretary general from meeting with Soviet officials in Cuba. Khrushchev was ready to offer the secretary general such meetings in an attempt to satisfy the Americans and meet their demand for UN inspection at least halfway. The meeting that took place on the afternoon of October 31 included not only the Soviet ambassador to Cuba, Aleksandr Alekseev, but also the commander of the missile division on the island, General Igor Statsenko.

The meeting was a substitute for U Thant's request to visit the Soviet missile installations, which Castro's protests rendered impossible. U Thant first raised the possibility of visiting the installations on October 29, one day before he departed for Cuba, in a meeting with Vasilii Kuznetsov, the Soviet first deputy foreign minister, who had been dispatched to New York by Khrushchev to enhance Soviet diplomacy at the UN during the crisis. U Thant asked Kuznetsov whether it would be possible for him to see missiles being removed while he was in Cuba. Kuznetsov, who believed that